AUDIENCE & CUSTOMER RESEARCH

B2B SaaS Buyer Research - Project Collaboration Platform

International customer research case focused on buying groups, hidden buyers and information needs

Portfolio Project	Audience & Customer Research	Market Type	International / B2B SaaS
Business Scenario	TaskPilot AI (hypothetical project collaboration SaaS)	Geography	US, UK and English-speaking global markets
Business Goal	Build a predictable pipeline from content-led demand among small and mid-sized teams	Primary Objective	Identify priority buyer segments, jobs-to-be-done, objections and buying-group influences to improve content relevance
Prepared By	SHAKIR HOSSAIN TALHA	Role	Social Media Strategist & Marketing Researcher
Research Date	15 February 2024	Research Mode	Desk research + strategic inference

In B2B SaaS, the person using the product is not always the person who can stop the deal.

Prepared for portfolio demonstration: research depth, strategic reasoning, customer understanding, market analysis, content/creative systems, and execution planning.

SHAKIR HOSSAIN TALHA
Social Media Strategist & Marketing Researcher
Research conducted: 15 February 2024

Scope note: This is a self-initiated portfolio simulation built from publicly available desk research. The business, goals and performance data in the scenario are hypothetical unless explicitly stated as an external benchmark. No client relationship or guaranteed result is claimed.

01. Executive Summary

The customer-research case begins with a core B2B reality: purchase influence can extend beyond the visible champion. Edelman and LinkedIn's 2025 B2B Thought Leadership Impact Report highlights “hidden buyers” such as finance, legal, procurement and operations as influential stakeholders. G2's 2026 small-business categories show strong usage of tools such as Asana and ClickUp among small businesses, while review summaries surface both strengths and learning-curve concerns. The implication is a research model that maps not only users, but the full buying group and the evidence each stakeholder needs.

Research Questions

- Who experiences the problem first?
- Who evaluates the solution?
- Who can block or accelerate the purchase?
- What information builds confidence at each buying stage?
- Which objections are product-specific versus organization-specific?

Key strategic conclusion

Do not market TaskPilot AI to “project managers” alone. Build a multi-stakeholder content system for operators, team leads and hidden buyers, with distinct proof for efficiency, security/governance, adoption and business impact.

Why this project belongs in a portfolio

- Deep audience segmentation
- Buying-group mapping
- Voice-of-customer style review synthesis

- Objection and evidence mapping
- Research-driven content implications

02. Market & Customer Research

The research focuses on the category rather than claiming any internal data for TaskPilot AI. G2 currently reports that 57% of Asana reviewers in the small-business project-management category come from small companies, and ClickUp is heavily represented by small-business reviewers. At the same time, the 2025 Edelman-LinkedIn report says over 40% of B2B deals stall due to internal misalignment within buying groups and that hidden buyers actively consume thought leadership.

Market evidence

Evidence	Public benchmark	Strategic implication
Buying group	Edelman/LinkedIn 2025 identifies hidden buyers across functions such as finance, legal, procurement and operations	Content must answer more than the end-user workflow question.
Category adoption	G2 2026 shows strong small-business representation for Asana and ClickUp reviews	SMB workflow pain is a viable research lens, but differentiation must be clearer than “all-in-one productivity.”
Decision confidence	Edelman/LinkedIn reports hidden buyers value bold, perspective-shifting thinking	Thought leadership can be used to create confidence before a sales conversation.

Customer research synthesis

The working research model is WHO -> JOB -> PROBLEM -> FEAR -> OBJECTION -> EVIDENCE -> DECISION ROLE -> LANGUAGE.

Stakeholder	Primary job	What they need to believe
Team lead / manager	Coordinate work and visibility	The system improves execution without adding admin burden.
Operations / COO	Standardize execution and reporting	Adoption, process consistency and measurable operational value are realistic.
Finance / procurement	Control cost and vendor risk	The economic case and procurement requirements are clear.
IT / security	Assess technical risk	Data handling, integrations and governance are credible.

03. Strategic Diagnosis

The likely problem is not a lack of possible buyers; it is incomplete communication of the buying committee's risk map. B2B content can over-index on the user interface and under-address business risk, adoption and governance.

Observed / inferred signals

- Product-category competition is crowded.
- Small-business reviewers care about ease, customization and workflow flexibility.
- Complex buying groups create invisible veto points.
- Thought leadership can influence buyers before they engage with sales.

Root-cause hypotheses

Hypothesis	Observed risk	Research method
Champion-only messaging	Content speaks to end user but not hidden buyer	Interview 3 roles per account; map objections
Feature overload	Too many capabilities increase perceived complexity	Review competitor language and demo objections
Weak business case	Prospects understand features but not value	Create ROI / workflow outcome narratives and test response
Governance gap	Security/procurement questions appear late	Build early-stage trust content and sales enablement

Priority decision

Build a buying-group audience map before building the content calendar. Every major pillar should answer a different stakeholder's “why should I trust this?” question.

04. Strategy & Strategic Architecture

The audience strategy uses a two-axis model: role and buying stage. That prevents generic “B2B persona” pages from becoming disconnected from actual decision behaviour.

Strategic architecture

Layer	Strategic choice	Execution direction
Primary segment	SMB / mid-market teams with workflow complexity	Focus on teams where coordination costs are visible.
Secondary stakeholders	Finance, operations, IT/security	Create hidden-buyer content and proof.
Message architecture	Outcome first, features second	Translate features into workflow and organizational consequences.
Content roles	Thought leadership + education + proof + objection handling	Use LinkedIn, case studies, diagrams, checklists and product proof.
Distribution	LinkedIn + search + sales enablement	Make high-value content easy for buyers to share internally.

Positioning / strategic choice

For growing teams whose work is becoming too complex for scattered tools, TaskPilot AI is a work-management platform positioned around operational clarity and adoption - not simply a longer feature list.

What we would deliberately avoid

- Do not target every company that manages projects.
- Do not assume the visible user is the only decision-maker.
- Do not treat feature count as differentiation.
- Do not build content solely around software screenshots.

05. Execution Plan & Portfolio Artifact

The portfolio artifact would be a research report plus a buying-group content matrix that links each stakeholder to jobs, objections, proof and messaging.

90-day / sprint priorities

Phase	Priority	Example actions
Research	Voice of customer	Analyze G2 review themes, win/loss notes, interviews and sales questions.
Segmentation	Buying-group map	Create user, champion, economic buyer, blocker and influencer profiles.
Content design	Stakeholder matrix	Assign content to stage + stakeholder + objection.
Activation	Thought leadership	Launch a series of bold operational points of view, then connect to case evidence and product proof.

Example deliverables

- Buying-group map
- Persona / JTBD cards
- Objection matrix
- Competitor review theme analysis
- Content-to-stakeholder matrix
- Research interview guide

Measurement framework

Objective	Primary KPI	Supporting signals
Audience resonance	Qualified engagement from target roles	Comments, shares, profile visits, repeat readership
Consideration	Content-assisted demo / high-intent action	Return visits, comparison-page activity
Pipeline quality	Qualified opportunities influenced	Opportunity-to-win rate by content exposure
Internal alignment	Sales usage of research assets	Asset adoption and qualitative sales feedback

06. Advanced Insight, Testing & Validation

The advanced lesson is audience depth: an audience is not a persona sentence; it is a map of jobs, fears, evidence and decision power. The hidden-buyer concept is a good example of how content strategy can improve when research follows the entire decision system.

Experiments / validation plan

Test	Variable	Decision rule
Role-specific landing pages	Generic vs role-specific message	Prioritize improved qualified engagement and demo quality.
Proof type	Feature list vs quantified process proof	Prefer lower-friction, higher-intent behaviour.
Thought leadership angle	Conventional best-practice vs assumption-challenging insight	Validate which creates meaningful target-account engagement.

Risks and research limitations

- G2 review summaries are category-level, not TaskPilot AI customer data.
- Edelman/LinkedIn findings are cross-market and not specific to one SaaS category.
- Actual buying groups vary by company size and procurement process.

What a real client engagement would validate next

- Interview champions and blockers separately.
- Mine lost deals for hidden objections.
- Tag sales-call questions by stakeholder role.
- Create a segment-by-stage content performance report.

07. Sources, Methods & Ownership

Source methodology

Sources were selected to support market context, platform behaviour, customer trust, competitor positioning, or operational practice. Recommendations are marked as strategic inference where they go beyond the source facts. External benchmarks are not presented as the hypothetical business's own results.

Research sources

#	Source	Publisher / Date	Use in research
1	2025 B2B Thought Leadership Impact Report	Edelman + LinkedIn | 2025	Buying-group and hidden-buyer research. https://www.edelman.com/expertise/Business-Marketing/2025-b2b-thought-leadership-report
2	2025 B2B Thought Leadership Impact Report - Key Learnings	Edelman + LinkedIn | 2025	Hidden-buyer content preferences and influence. https://www.edelman.com/sites/g/files/aatuss191/files/2025-07/2025%20Edelman-LinkedIn%20B2B%20Thought%20Leadership%20Impact%20Report_FINAL.pdf
3	Best Project Management Software for Small Business in 2026	G2 | 2026	Category and review-theme benchmark. https://www.g2.com/categories/project-management/small-business

#	Source	Publisher / Date	Use in research
4	Best Task Management Software for Small Business in 2026	G2 | 2026	Small-business reviewer and feature-theme benchmark. https://www.g2.com/categories/task-management-software/small-business

Professional integrity note

This document demonstrates research and strategic reasoning. It does not claim that the hypothetical company implemented the recommendations or achieved the projected outcomes. Any client-facing version should replace assumptions with first-party analytics, interviews, customer data, financial inputs, and legal/compliance review where applicable.